

University of Rochester
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Joy Oriented Literacy Pursuit

Reflective Journal

Classroom Technology, Design, and Literacy as Joy

A Teaching Neurodivergent Journal focused on Literacy & Joy via a Puzzle Plan

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Assignment Joy Oriented Literacy Pursuit

Context Teaching Reflection through the Lens of this course & a Puzzle Plan

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Joy oriented literacy is not extra. It is part of access. When students feel capable, connected, and allowed to participate as themselves, literacy becomes a tool for liberation, agency, and empowerment.

Author's Context Note: This journal is viewed through two personal frameworks I developed to redesign exclusionary systems. The **Puzzle Plan** connects lessons as "puzzle pieces" toward intersectional and neurodivergent inclusive environments. **EQUITAS** is my equity centered diagnostic framework, adapted here from my bioinformatics research to ask whether classroom tasks offer fair, culturally responsive, and multiple pathways for students to demonstrate literacy without being misread as "deficient."

What I Created and Who I Shared It With

For my joy oriented literacy pursuit, I treated my *Puzzle Plan and EQUITAS framework* as an ongoing literacy project in action. The classroom lessons I facilitated became the project outputs: moments where students experienced literacy through building, collaboration, speaking, movement, problem solving, and shared excitement. The strongest examples came from my Kindergarten squishy circuit lessons with airplanes, light bulbs, and motor based fans, along with Minecraft lessons in Grades 3 and 4. These activities were shared with the classroom community because students built, watched, helped, revised, and learned from one another in real time. Their feedback was immediate and visible through questions, corrections, peer troubleshooting, and the shared countdown when the circuit finally worked.¹

In Kindergarten, students learned about batteries, switches, conductors, and insulators by holding materials, connecting pieces, and counting down together before the fan turned on. In the airplane building lesson, students worked in teams, taking roles such as building wings or connecting the fan to a switch.² In Grade 4 Minecraft, students who finished helped classmates troubleshoot, turning digital literacy into peer teaching and community responsibility.³

Seen through a Universal Design for Learning (UDL) lens, each lesson became a different piece of my larger Puzzle Plan. As someone whose undiagnosed ADHD and chronic illness were consistently misread by educational systems as deficits, I designed these lessons to do the opposite. The Kindergarten circuits emphasized multiple ways to engage: students touched materials, heard vocabulary, and participated physically. The Minecraft lessons emphasized multiple ways to express understanding: students coded, debugged, and explained. This project was not only about creating fun lessons; it was about testing whether literacy is more joyful when students are not forced to mask their neurodivergence to participate.

The community also included me as a teacher and learner. I was not only facilitating the lessons; I was also noticing which materials, roles, and supports made students' thinking more visible. That is what the Puzzle Plan helps me name: every lesson shows me which conditions allow students to stop hiding and start showing what they know.

¹Placement evidence: six documented examples across Grade 4 and Kindergarten

²Kindergarten transcript evidence, circuit demo and airplane prep

³Grade 4 transcript evidence, Minecraft agent challenge

My Creative and Learning Process

My creative process began with a deeply personal question: *how can technology lessons become sites of visibility rather than sites of erasure?* Knobel and Lankshear helped me name these moments as new literacies because students were making meaning through digital, visual, and networked practices. Price Dennis, Holmes, and Smith helped me connect this to access.

In the squishy circuit lessons, I used switches, batteries, wires, and fans to connect vocabulary to action. Students did not only hear the word “switch”; they held it and watched the physical consequence of their logic.⁴ In Minecraft, I treated students who finished early as class resources rather than treating completion as the end of learning. That shifted the lesson from “I am done” to “I can help someone else succeed,” allowing one student to troubleshoot while another deepened mastery through explanation.⁵

I began to see the lessons as small design experiments mirroring my data science research. In bioinformatics, I map hidden biomarkers; in this classroom, I mapped hidden literacies. If a student explained a circuit orally but could not write a full explanation, that counted as literacy. If a student debugged a Minecraft path by counting blocks and revising commands, that counted as literacy. These moments helped me trust that intelligence was already present; my responsibility was to design the conditions where it could become legible.

This process taught me to notice joy as an equity metric. Joy happened because students had access to materials, roles, and visible success without the anxiety of a single, rigid assessment. Pinkard’s ecosystem view helped me name this: students need tools, mentors, audiences, and real reasons to create. Stornaiuolo and Thomas helped me see digital literacy as agency. My design principle became simple: *students need enough structure to feel safe and enough freedom to feel ownership*. For me, that principle was not abstract. It came directly from years of being a student whose literacy was invisible because the task only had one door.

⁴Evidence: Example 5, vocabulary and collective participation

⁵Evidence: Example 2, peer teaching as joyful expertise

How This Cultivated Joy, Love, and Aesthetic Fulfillment

As a child who grew up in the Dominican Republic navigating poverty, the loss of my mother at seven, and systems that demanded survival over self expression, school was rarely a site of joy for me. Personally, my aesthetic fulfillment came from witnessing the exact opposite in my students. The joy in these lessons came from collective anticipation: Kindergarteners watched the pieces connect, counted down together, and saw the fan turn on.⁶ The science became visible, audible, and shared.

The lessons also created aesthetic fulfillment because students built objects with shape, motion, and purpose. Love appeared through relationships. In Minecraft, the student who finished early was not removed from the learning community; he became part of someone else's success. Success was not private or competitive; it became something students could give to each other.⁷ That changed the emotional structure of the classroom into one of shared possibility.

These moments reminded me that joy in literacy does not always look quiet or neat. Sometimes it looks like trying again, arguing productively, or realizing that one's hands and neurodivergent thinking matter. My joy came from seeing students who might have been pathologized by traditional print only literacy tasks become entirely visible as builders, explainers, and collaborators.

Muhammad's Framework and the Case for Literacy as Access

Muhammad's framework insists that a literacy pursuit should develop identity, skills, intellect, criticality, and joy together. The Kindergarten circuits and Minecraft lessons were not just STEM activities. They helped students build technical vocabulary while seeing themselves as contributors.

Price-Dennis, Holmes, and Smith connected the work to inclusive digital literacy because students need more than one pathway to show understanding. Brooks and Frankel's work on transnational digital literacy matters because students bring identity and community knowledge into classroom technologies. When a student builds in Minecraft, explains a circuit orally, or helps a peer troubleshoot, that student is practicing literacy. In my Kindergarten and Grade 4 lessons, students did exactly this; navigating tools, relationships, and roles in ways that deserved to be named as literacy rather than dismissed as play.

⁶Evidence: Example 5, collective countdown and fan circuit demo

⁷Evidence: Example 2, peer teaching in the Minecraft session

Melo-Pfeifer and Gertz pushed me to think about criticality because digital spaces are not neutral. Students need to question assumptions and representation. Common Sense Digital Citizenship extends this through privacy, audience, and community responsibility. Pinkard reminds us that students need tools and mentors, while Serpagli and Mensah's work with social media style science learning connects to my examples because students used active forms to explain technical ideas. Together, these readings show that digital literacy should position students as creators, not just consumers.

How This Informs My Future Teaching

This experience solidifies my belief that literacy is not limited to written language. It is building, coding, explaining, translating, and troubleshooting. In my classroom, I will consistently design activities with multiple entry points, intentionally building for students who are multilingual, neurodivergent, chronically ill, or otherwise different from the “default” learner schools often imagine.

This directly transforms my approach to assessment. I want to document literacy through observation, photos of student products, peer explanations, and moments of revision. A written response can matter, but it should never be the sole proof of learning. Especially in technology rich environments, students often show profound understanding through action before they can translate it into academic English.

My biggest takeaway is that joy oriented literacy is a fundamental component of diagnostic justice. Through my *Puzzle Plan and EQUITAS lens*, the critical question is whether a task gives students real access to meaning, identity, and agency. In my bioinformatics research, EQUITAS audits algorithms to prevent the erasure of marginalized patients. In the classroom, EQUITAS does the exact same thing for literacy: it demands we stop using narrow metrics that erase neurodivergent and culturally diverse students. When students feel capable, connected, and allowed to participate as themselves, literacy ceases to be a tool of compliance and becomes a practice of liberation.

Placement Evidence

The examples in this journal are documented with teaching evidence including transcript excerpts, teaching move analysis, and privacy safe photographs: full evidence document with six examples and images, Grade 4 Minecraft transcript, and Kindergarten circuit transcript. https://github.com/pzg8794/EDU498-joy_oriented_literacy_pursuit_journal/blob/main/joy-evidence-from-placement.md